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Attorney Tops Field in Special Election to Replace Dababneh

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LOS ANGELES (CNS) — Democrat Jesse Gabriel will face Republican Justin Clark June 5 to fill the 45th Assembly District seat made vacant by the resignation of Matt Dababneh.

Gabriel, a constitutional rights attorney and a member of the county Commission on Local Government Services, topped the eight-candidate field in Tuesday's special election with 32 percent of the vote, according to semi-official results released Wednesday, April 4, by the Los Angeles County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk.

Clark, a 19-year-old Cal State Northridge student who was the lone Republican on the ballot, was second with 26.99 percent. Tricia Robbins Kasson, an aide to City Councilman Bob Blumenfield, was third with 16.01 percent.

Former Los Angeles City Councilmember Dennis Zine, who dropped out of the race after the deadline to remove his name from the ballot, was fifth with 8.44 percent. He was listed on the ballot as having no party preference.

Because no candidate received more than 50 percent of the vote, the top two finishers will face off June 5.

Gabriel, Clark, Robbins Kasson and four other Democrats who were on the special election ballot will also be on the June 5 primary ballot, seeking spots on the November ballot for a full two-year term.

Registration in the district that includes Encino, Northridge, Reseda, Woodland Hills, Tarzana, Calabasas and Winnetka, is about 49 percent Democrat, according to the Secretary of State's Office.

Dababneh, a Woodland Hills Democrat, resigned at the end of December. He had been accused of sexual misconduct by at least two women, including a female lobbyist who said Dababneh masturbated in front of her during a party in Las Vegas.

Dababneh denied any wrongdoing.

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